# JOHN R. MOTT

## A LIFETIME OF ACCOMPLISHMENT

By

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Ask a young Christian leader today about John R. Mott, and most would be hard-pressed to remember who he was or what he accomplished. But few in Christian history, certainly fewer in the past hundred years, have accomplished so much, or changed the face of Christendom so profoundly. Who was John R. Mott and what can leaders today learn from his life?

The definitive work by Charles Hopkins, *John R. Mott, 1865-1955: A Biography*, reveals a ninety-year-long life of enormous influence, despite the humble beginnings of this third son of John S. and Elmira Mott, born at the close of the Civil War on their farm in Sullivan Country, New York, May 25, 1865. Princeton Theological Seminary President John A. Mackay said of Mott: ". . . I believe [him] to be the greatest Christian statesman of our century . . ." (Fisher 1952:77). Latourette went so far as to call him more instrumental than any other person since the Apostle Paul to spreading the Gospel: "No one since the days of St. Paul has done so much to spread the Gospel of Jesus Christ as Dr. Mott" (Mackie 1965: Back Cover). He captured the imagination of a whole generation of Christians and catalyzed their energies to venture into new fields, new arenas of influence on the world.

The sheer number of Mott's leadership roles, when listed, are nearly unbelievable: twenty-seven years as national secretary of the American and Canadian Intercollegiate Y.M.C.A.; Chairman of the executive committee of the Student Volunteer Movement for Foreign Missions; presiding officer of the World Missionary Conference (Edinburgh 1910); IMC Chairman; Organizer and General Secretary of the World's Student Christian Federation; organizer of national student movements in India, China, Japan, Australia, New Zealand, Europe and the USA; General-Secretary of the International Committee of the Y.M.C.A; President of the Y.M.C.A.'s World Committee.

While Mott personally planted no churches among unreached tribes, in the years following the release of his 1900 book calling for “the evangelization of the world in this generation,” his message catalyzed more than 20,000 missionaries to go out in pursuit of the vision the book articulated.

During his long life of leadership, he wrote sixteen books, but his leadership was never merely philosophical--an ivory tower Aristotle developing noteworthy concepts for someone else to work out. Mott excelled as a doer and a goer. Between 1912 and 1913, for instance, he led twenty-one regional missionary conferences in India, China, Japan, and Korea. Over a period of fifty years, he crossed the Atlantic over one hundred times and the Pacific fourteen times. In fact, it was estimated that at the time he received the Nobel Peace Prize, in 1946, he had traveled two million miles in pursuit of his calling. Before each trip, he studied intently about each nation’s culture, customs, religious and political background, so that he was able to communicate as one who understood his audience. At his Nobel award speech, the presenter affirmed that “He was never an American bringing an evangelical message to Poland, to South America, or to the East, in an American style. He was an apostle of a simple Christianity, presented in a form which made it living and real to the people to whom it was addressed” (Ingebretsen 1946).

While he was motivated completely by a desire to serve Christ and the Gospel, he believed that evangelism must be paired with social action, and earned the trust of Christian and secular leader alike. He found a kindred spirit in President Wilson (president from 1912 to 1920), who offered him the ambassadorship to China, which he declined, but served in 1916 as a member of the Mexican Commission. In 1917, the year of both the Russian Revolution and America’s entry into World War I, Mott served on a diplomatic mission to Russia. Under President Wilson, he became General Secretary of the National War Work Council, receiving the Distinguished Service Medal for his service.

Near the end of the First World War, he rallied those involved in his organizations to welfare work among the soldiers at the front and brought relief to millions of prisoners of war on both sides. He himself traveled from country to country and visiting the fronts, entering into negotiations with statesmen from warring nations, recruiting helpers for this vast project. And, to fund this work, he collected $250 million in donations. He did all this with characteristic excellence.

After the war, he turned his prodigious abilities to organizing social work among the demobilized soldiers. Soon, he and his assistants were invited to lead rehabilitation efforts in various countries. He was honored widely for his various endeavors. In addition to the Service Medal, he received awards from China, Czechoslovakia, Finland, France, Greece, Hungary, Italy, Japan, Jerusalem, Poland, Greece, Estonia, Norway, Portugal, Siam, Sweden, and the United States; six honorary degrees from the universities of Brown, Edinburgh, Princeton, Toronto, Yale and Upper Iowa; an honorary degree from the Russian Orthodox Church of Paris; and the Nobel Peace Prize in 1946.

And his influence did not end with his death. His biographer, Howard Hopkins, sums up Mott's effect on today's world: "His influence lives not only in world bodies such as the W.C.C. and the World's Alliance of YMCA's, but in the profound effect he exerted upon individuals of several generations who volunteered their contributions to the evangelization, the betterment, the unity of the world in their time" (Hopkins 1979:83).

## CRITICAL INCIDENTS

Leaders can often point to specific events, specific realizations, that changed their life purpose and altered their destiny. How did a farm boy from Sullivan County come to achieve so much on a global scale? We can trace his development through a series of *Prime Critical Incidents*

### *Incident 1: 1886--The decision to present Christ to students*

In January 1886, While Mott was a student at Cornell University, a famous British cricketer, J.K. Studd (brother of C.T. Studd, one of the Cambridge Seven) spoke at the school. He challenged Mott personally with what Mott later recorded as "three short sentences which proved to be the turning point in my life…'Seekest thou great things for thyself? Seek them not. Seek ye first the Kingdom of God.'…on these few words hinged my life-investment decision" (Mathews 1934:35)

### *Incident 2: 1886--Mt. Hermon Conference*

Later in 1886, Dwight Moody was the main speaker at a college conference held for twenty-six days at Mount Hermon, Massachusetts. Among the 250 young men from eighty-nine colleges gathered there was 21-year-old Mott, available and open to God's next step. It was not Moody, but A.T. Pierson who struck the match to ignite Mott's heart. His message "All Should Go and Go To All" motivated Mott and ninety-nine others to sign a paper that read "We are willing and desirous, God permitting, to become foreign missionaries…" These became known as the "Mount Hermon Hundred."

Mott was selected with three others as a delegation to spread this vision to all the colleges and universities in North America. This was the genesis of the Student Volunteer Movement (S.V.M.). They adopted the watchword "The Evangelization of the World in This Generation," and organized formally with Mott as their chair. He was only 21 years old.

Within a few years, over 5,000 students had signed the pledge. Respected missiologist, Verkuyl, affirmed the impact of the S.V.M. that emerged, calling it "the greatest missionary movement since Pentecost." Its missionaries spread out over all six continents, and still today traces of its influence are clearly visible in the churches of Asia, Africa, and Latin America (Verkuyl 1978:180).

The need was great. In 1878, only 2,000 Protestant missionaries were at work overseas among 856,000,000 unevangelized people. Ultimately 100,000 students would pledge their lives to missionary work, and at least 20,500, a conservative estimate, would serve overseas (Cumming 1988:2).

### *Incident 3: 1888--Young Men's Christian Association*

Mott had become a charter member of the new Young Men's Christian Association while an eighteen-year-old student at Upper Iowa University. He transferred to Cornell as a sophomore and was soon elected vice-president of that YMCA. His characteristic striving for excellence was revealed in a letter to his parents that he was determined to make the Association the best of all the college YMCA's (Hopkins 1979:16). As a junior, he was elected president of the Cornell University Christian Association. His senior year, he became traveling secretary of the Collegiate Committee of the national YMCA, and was an immediate success (Hopkins 1979:43-47). Leadership of the YMCA was at the heart of Mott's ministry until the Edinburgh 1910 conference.

As leader of the North American Student Volunteer Movement, Mott soon realized that those who signed the pledge in response to his message formed bands of volunteers in competition with the YMCA. In the exercise of his formidable persuasive influence, he worked out a simple organization composed of officials of various Christian organizations and constituted one committee to represent them all. This became known as the Executive Committee of the SVM of Foreign Missions. Under Mott's leadership, the Associations in the colleges now became missionary in outlook and action. "On this apparently unimportant decision depended not simply the future work of Mott, but in a very real sense the whole history of the world Christian movement" (Mathews 1934:84).

### *Incident 4: 1895--World's Student Christian Federation*

In 1895 Mott's dream of a world organization crystallized into a definite scheme. This began a new chapter in Mott's ministry: laying the foundation overseas of the Christian student movement vision. Mott's scope of influence crossed the North American borders to the world beyond.

At a meeting in Vatsdena Castle in Sweden, a constitution for a world organization of students was framed with three objectives:

1) to unite student Christian movements throughout the world,

2) to collect information regarding the religious condition of the students of all lands and

3) to promote the following lines of activity: (a) to lead students to become disciples of Jesus Christ as the only Saviour and God, (b) to deepen the spiritual life of students, and (c) to enlist students in the work of extending the Kingdom of Christ throughout the whole world.

Mott was jubilant and optimistic as he assumed leadership of this new body, "Never since the Wartburg sheltered the great German reformer while he was translating the Bible for the common people has a medieval castle served a purpose fraught with larger blessing to all mankind" (Mathews 1934:108).

From 1895-1897, Mott toured India, China, Japan and Australia on behalf of the organization, drawing youth into personal discipleship to Christ and to a commitment for spreading the gospel worldwide.

### *Incident 5: Edinburgh 1910*

The ensuing worldwide movement culminated in a conference held in Edinburgh in 1910, hosting 1,200 delegates from 160 mission boards or societies. Not surprisingly, Mott was invited to chair, first the commission on "Carrying the Gospel to All the non-Christian World," and later the conference itself.

John Stott, speaking in 1975 to students at Cambridge University, interpreted the worldview of the Edinburgh conference, calling it "Edinburgh euphoria." There was an overwhelming optimism in the *doability* of the task of world evangelization. As Stott also pointed out though, this optimism was soon to be shattered by the realities of World War I.

Following the Edinburgh conference, Mott wrote a book to describe the situation confronting the missionary forces of Christendom, *The Decisive Hour of Christian Missions*, published the next year. The content of the book was based on information furnished by eight different commissions which had met for eighteen months prior to the conference. The book's first half described the conditions in the non-Christian world. The second presents the need as 1) an adequate home base, 2) an efficient Church on the mission field, and 3) the "Superhuman factor" (Mott 1911:2). The book carried Mott's message beyond students, to church and mission leaders worldwide.

The Continuation committee of the conference (of which Mott was the chair) commissioned him to spend two years visiting the countries of the world to spread the vision.

### *Incident 6: 1921--The International Missionary Council*

Eleven years after the Edinburgh conference, the continuation committee transformed into the IMC, meeting at Jerusalem in 1928, and Madras in 1938. Mott was again affirmed as chairman and symbol. It signaled an alignment of mission agencies toward unity, drawn together by common bonds of evangelism and mission. This was the first time in history that the non-Catholic world had a global structure for international and inter-confessional cooperation (Bosch 1991:463). The development of the IMC for Mott was the fulfillment of his dream of a global structure that would catalyze unity for the sake of mission. Mott was integral to the formation of thirty national councils of churches in as many countries (Hopkins 1981:83).

This ecumenical spirit later gave birth to the World Council of Churches, giving Mott the epithet, “father of the WCC.” But Mott, toward the end of his life, had grave reservations about such a body, “not motivated by missions, and fear[ed] that the World Council might swallow the International Missionary Council” (Hopkins 1979:689). Mott’s fears were realized after his death, when, in 1961, the IMC merged with the WCC at the New Delhi Assembly.

### *Incident 7: 1931--The Present-Day Summons*

Two decades after Edinburgh, Christian leaders in Europe and the United States approached Mott to write about the developments of the previous two decades since Edinburgh. The publication of this book, *The Present-Day Summons to the World Mission of Christianity,* reflects a more sober, post-war perspective than his earlier works. Mott now focuses on the needs, rather than the optimistic possibilities. He describes the summons of rural life, (Africa, Asia, and Latin America’s rural communities); of industry; of race *(*the need for solutions to racial violence and tensions), and the need for the Church to share, serve and cooperate in responding to each summons.

## LESSONS IN LEADERSHIP

The Bible encourages Christians to study the lives of godly leaders and discover meaningful lessons from how they lived. “Remember your leaders, who spoke the word of God to you. Consider the outcome of their way of life and imitate their faith” (Heb. 13:7). In surveying Mott’s weighty accomplishments, one can conjecture that here was a person enabled, beyond any human imagination, to be a choice instrument of God in leadership for his generation, worthy of examination and emulation in any era.

### *Personal Ethics*

Mott's private life and ethics shaped what He was to become in his public life. Biographer Hopkins observed, "At least four other factors molded Mott's viewpoint: the Bible, the practice of prayer, his continent-wide and world-circling travel among the colleges and universities, and his preparation for this by extensive reading"

But these were primarily the activities that shaped him. On a deeper level, though, in the execution of these actions could be found an even more important list that affected every thought. It was a series of questions he would ask of himself, as if standing outside himself and evaluating. From these may be drawn nine principles of a highly effective leader of influence

Does he do little things well? (the principle of excellence)

Has he learned the meaning of priorities? (the principle of focus)

How does he use his leisure? (the principle of rest)

Has he intensity? (the principle of passion)

Has he learned to take advantage of momentum? (the principle of timing)

Has he the power of growth? (the principle of a learning posture)

What is his attitude toward discouragements? (the principle of resilience)

How does he face impossible situations? (the principle of faith)

What are his weakest points? (the principle of humility)

Mott not only prayed, but he also practiced the presence of God in his daily life, believing that whatever he was able to accomplish was due to prayer. In spite of his popular image as the great religious entrepreneur, many remember him chiefly as a man of prayer. As he traveled the world, he read voraciously for background, not only in current affairs, but in history and culture. By these means, Mott grew from a somewhat provincial American into a citizen of the world and as such was welcomed on campuses from Berkeley to Oxford to Sydney.

## USE OF EFFECTIVE METHODOLOGIES IN DECISION MAKING

Mott was known for his expeditious and wise decision-making process. He wrote to his father explaining how he came to make the decision to accept the intercollegiate secretary position of the Young Men's Christian Association in a letter on April 28, 1888.

There are two things I hope to convince you of in my life: First—that I do not jump at a decision, but consider it from all sides, getting advice from every reliable source, and then reaching from the conflicting opinions my own decision. Second—that I am not led by others, even by a large majority, unless they happen to be in harmony with my standards of decision. Those standards are:

The Holy Spirit, who guides in cooperation with

The Scriptures;

Reason—not feeling;

Conscience;

Providential events (Mathews 1934:77).

### *Faith in the God of the Impossible to Do the Impossible*

One of the strengths of Mott's leadership was his faith in God to do what seems impossible. "More and more I have come to see that from the Christian point of view it is easier not only to undertake but to accomplish the impossible than it is the possible" (Mott 1930). He considered it easier for a Christian to undertake the impossible than it is the easy, and he explained why. "The impossible kindles and exercises the imagination. The impossible calls out all of our other latent powers"

### Mission Mobilizer par Excellence

Mott recognized the importance of cultivating a common vision for the purposes of mobilizing God's people for world evangelization. Though he did not coin the phrase, "The Evangelization of the World in this Generation," he understood its significance for

his generation at the 1886 student gathering in Mt. Hermon where he received his own missionary call.

As a promoter, Mott used this common vision to catalyze a world mission movement. He mobilized with far-reaching impact, as more than 20,000 students went out as missionaries in the early part of the twentieth century. He reflected on the watchword in 1900:

A watchword which has in so brief a time gained a powerful hold on the minds of the future leaders of thought, and which is already beginning to make itself felt in the Church, is manifestly worthy of careful consideration. In such a consideration it is important that we clearly understand at the outset what is meant by the evangelization of the world in this generation. It means to give all men an adequate opportunity to know Jesus Christ as their Saviour and to become His real disciples. This involves such a distribution of missionary agencies as will make the knowledge of the Gospel accessible to all men.

There were some serious critics of the watchword, including Professor Gustav Warneck, who, according to John Stott, ". . . attacked it . . . on the ground that it was a naively optimistic and rather man-confident forecast that the world would be won for Christ in that generation" (Stott 1975:39). Mott rallied to the watchword's defense[1]. "He

[1] The watchword, [Mott] said, means the giving to all men an adequate opportunity of knowing Jesus Christ as their Saviour and of becoming His real disciples.' This is what Christ implied in the Great Commission. It means preaching the gospel to those who are now living; it does not mean the conversion of the world, according to Mott" (Anderson 1988:101).

Wilder kept a list of the criticisms of the watchword with his own responses.

1. It suggests a hasty, superficial preaching of the Gospel. Answer: We advocate no such thing.
2. That it overlooks other important missionary work. Answer: We emphasize educational, medical, etc.
3. That it stands in service of certain millennial views. Answer: We are loyal to all leading denominations.
4. That it overlooks obstacles in the way. Answer: See Cleveland Convention Report in which so much time given to obstacles.
5. That it is a false prophesy. Answer: We venture no prediction.
6. That it requires too much explanation. Answer: Every watchword has required explanation.
7. It is not a prophecy of what is sure to occur. We can emphasize a duty without venturing a prediction. (Cumming 1988:105)

maintained that 'the evangelization of the world' meant neither its conversion nor its Christianization, that it did not encourage superficial preaching and that it was not to be understood as a prophecy" (Stott 1975:39). But others, Principal Cairns of Aberdeen, for instance, saw Mott's interpretation and advocacy of the watchword as "one of his most distinctive and vital contributions" (Rouse 1920:6).

**Exemplification of Christian Leadership**

How was Mott able to lead in such an extraordinary way? Fuller Seminary professor, Bobby Clinton, defines a Christian leader as follows: "A leader, in the biblical context, is a person, with God-given capacity AND with God-given responsibility TO INFLUENCE a specific group of God's people toward God's purposes for the group" (Clinton 1992:62, emphasis is his).

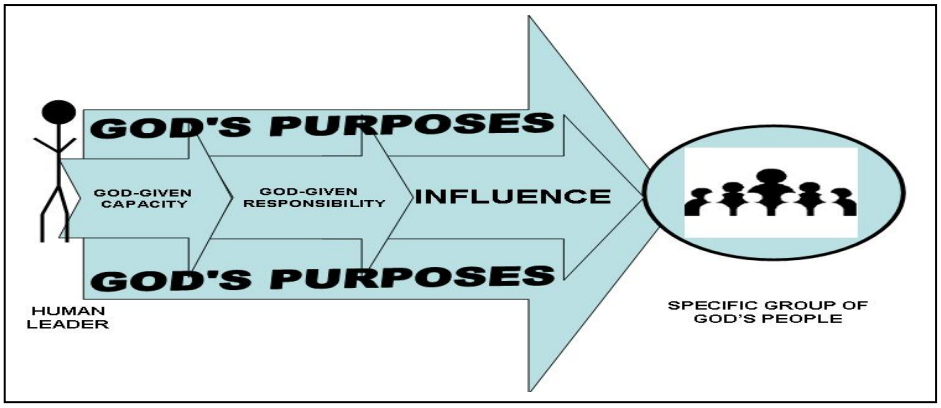



**FIGURE 1**

**WHAT IS A CHRISTIAN LEADER?**

According to Figure 1, the basis for Christian leadership is found in God's purposes for a specific group of his people. Within his purposes for that group, he calls forth a human leader to be the instrument to influence that group of people toward God's purposes for them. The influence of the leader on the group comes from both his God-

given responsibility and God-given capacity. Like a hand in a glove the God-given capacity enables the leader to fulfill his God-given responsibility to influence the group. By acting according to God's design for His people, Mott influenced thousands of Christian young people, leaders and even secular leaders toward God's purposes.

Mott's leadership capacity also came from his innate talent for speaking and motivating. It was the talent most often used by God to influence others. One participant in the Edinburgh conference recorded

When he himself addresses an assembly, [he] knits and kindles the craggy, tender face; the voice vibrates with fierce emphases and stresses. The single words seem literally to fall from his lips (the trite expression is for once justified), finished off with a deliberation that never slurs one final consonant, but on the contrary gives that consonant the duty of driving its word home. And as for the sentences also—the conclusion of each, instead of dropping in tone, increases to a sort of defiant *sforzando*, which, when his earnestness is at its height, can be terrific (Galli 2000).

**Living a Focused Life**

Regardless of how one would define the word, "focus", one would have to conclude that Mott lived a focused life. One part of "focus" is the leader's ability to focus all of his faculties on the task or person at hand. For example, on one occasion, when Mott was in his eighties, he was in a train station. He spotted a Christian leader and approached him. Looking deep into his eyes, he asked how it was with him and in his relationship with Christ. Despite the commotion of people and bustle of activity around them, the leader later said he experienced "a sense of exclusive focus on his person" (Shenk 2001).

Another aspect of the concept of focus is the leader's ability to focus on the highest priorities. From his early twenties, Mott's life was dedicated to God's unique

purpose for him. “. . . he has dedicated and disciplined every power of body, mind and spirit to incessant battle across the world, through decade after decade, for the Kingdom of God” (Mathews 1934:x). He maintained this ability to maintain focus until the end of his varied life. In what would be his final public appearance, he said "While life lasts, I am an evangelist." Mott died in 1955.

**Pursuing a Life Purpose**

Mott’s life purpose was to make Jesus Christ known, obeyed, and loved throughout the world (Hopkins 1979:279, 629). “His great aim, repeatedly stated in thousands of speeches around the world, was ‘to make Jesus Christ known, trusted, loved, obeyed, and exemplified in the whole range of individual life and in all human relationships’” (Hopkins 1979:625). In pursuit of this objective, Mott planned, organized, traveled, lectured, wrote and raised funds tirelessly.

In order to achieve his greater life purpose, Mott developed, early in his life, personal purposes that corporately acted as a rudder to keep his life balanced and moving towards his central purpose, and the fixed, monumental goals proceeding from it. Part of this came from the watchword itself. Thirty years after the adoption of the watchword, Mott said: “I can truthfully answer that next to the decision to take Christ as the leader and Lord of my life, the watchword has had more influence than all other ideals and objectives combined…” He reflected on its significance:

To widen my horizon and enlarge my conception of the Kingdom of God

To hold me steadfast in the face of criticism, opposition and other obstacles to the great Christ-commanded purpose of seeking first the Kingdom of God;

To stimulate my personal preparation for my service to my generation;

To deepen my conviction as to the necessity of furthering the more intensive aspects of the missionary enterprises such as educational missions, the building up of strong native Churches, and the raising up of an able indigenous leadership;

To recognize and promote the essential strategy involved in establishing an adequate home base, and in Christianizing the impact of the so-called Christian nations on the non-Christian world;

To appreciate vividly both the social and the individual aspects of the Christian Gospel and likewise their essential unity; to see the necessity of linking together the Christian students of all lands and races, and of raising up from among them an army of well-furnished, God-called heroic Volunteers;

To realize and live under the spell of the great urgency of the task of giving each generation an adequate opportunity to know Christ; and above all,

To deepen acquaintance with God and to throw us back on Him for ever-fresh accessions of superhuman wisdom, love and power.

The cornerstone of Mott's activities was a vision of the Kingdom of God based on individuals transformed by the call of God and moral fortitude. Societal issues such as labor conflict, big money, and imperialism were viewed through the lenses of this vision with a seemingly simplistic confidence undoubtedly heartening to a large body of the American population (Smalley 1980).

### *Mechanisms Mott Developed to Carry Out His Vision*

Mott used specific means to carry out his visionary ideas. He devised mechanisms and structures through which he channeled his formidable leadership gifting to fulfill God's purposes as he interpreted them. These mechanisms included conferences, organizations, mentoring, bridge building, and writings.

**Conferences**

Mott's method for preparing for a conference proved to be highly effective. The methodology was implemented with unsurpassed thoroughness as chairman of the Edinburgh 1910 Continuation Committee through twenty-one follow-up conferences. A questionnaire was sent out in advance to catalyze the process of discussion, seeking factual, creative and forward-looking results. Great efforts were undertaken to ensure the presence of the leading missionaries and Christian nationals at each provincial gathering. Having both leading nationals and internationals present encouraged different points of view, knowledge which was then used for findings and resolutions. Mott raised the finances for the printing, mailing and gatherings from sources that did not affect the missionary's field budgets. With the dominant lesson out of Edinburgh 1910 being the need for greater cooperation, the resolutions related to ways of cooperating in each one of the regions. In China, for example, there were six areas identified, each holding a sectional conference. Typically, the conferences resulted in the establishment, not only of one national body, called a national Christian council, but also a commitment to a whole range of cooperative projects in literature, evangelism, social problems and education (Mathews 1934:227-228).

**Organizations**

Mott's platform of global ministry was organizational. He built organizations, developed them, expanded them and occasionally founded new ones to accommodate the broadening sphere of influence. On one occasion, Mott made a worldwide tour representing no less than four organizations (Hopkins 1979:633). He was an organization's man. He was either the executive secretary or became an executive chairman.

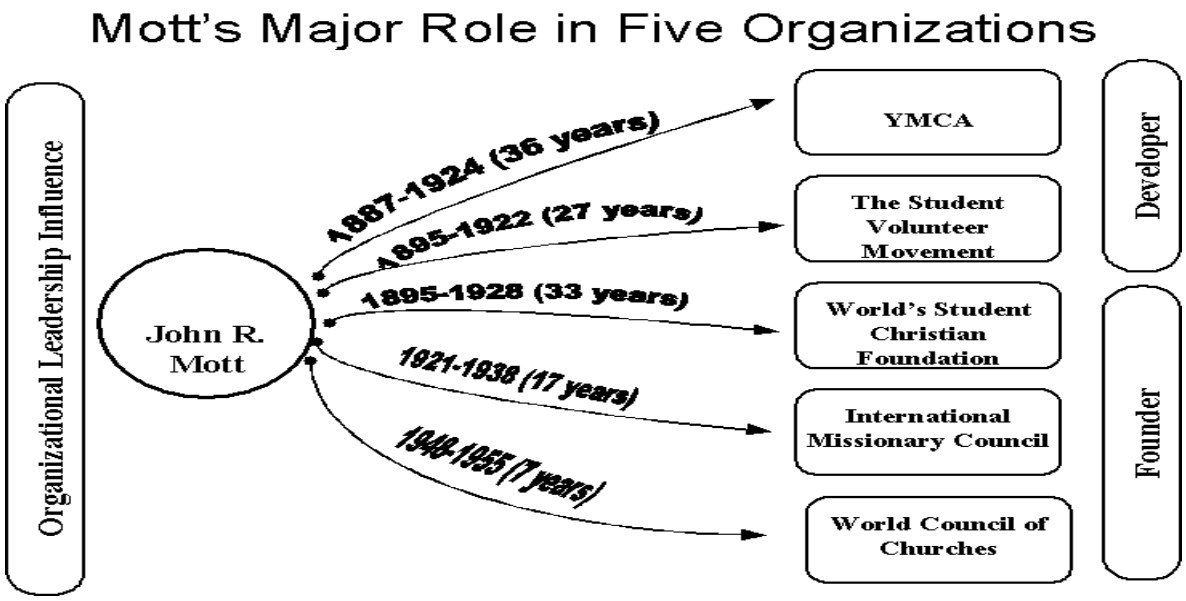



**FIGURE 2**

**ORGANIZATIONS INFLUENCED BY MOTT**

Mott was unusual in that he not only had the ability to take a fledgling organization, bring stability, and expand its influence, but also to start new organizations. He was instrumental in founding a number of organizations. The most noteworthy with regard to recognizing his influence are WSCF, the IMC and the WCC. The historian of the WSCF (Hopkins 1979:128) calls Mott "the greatest leader the Y.M.C.A. has ever known…" (Rouse 1920:1). And in Smalley we find the following:

He served as administrator and leader of various organizations including the Young Men's Christian Association, Student Volunteer Movement for Foreign Missions, World Student Christian Federation, Foreign Missions Conference of North America, IMC, Interchurch World Movement, Institute of Social and Religious Research and the World Council of Churches (Smalley 1980).

The formation of the WSCF in 1895 was Mott's most creative achievement (Hopkins 1979). When he suggested someone else write the history of the Federation, a friend wrote back, "You are the history of the Federation" (Rouse 1920:1). He became

convinced that the time had come to establish a worldwide union of Christian students and devoted two years to bringing this about. His rationale was that students are primary instruments to move the world toward God (Rouse 1920:2).

As Mott transitioned from student work to mission and church work worldwide, the primary organizational platform bearing the influence of his ministry also shifted:

As he had earlier concentrated on the World's Student Christian Federation, the influence of which was pervasive and universal, in his last active years he gave himself fully to the I.M.C. Through its chairmanship he exerted both a symbolic and a direct influence upon the world Council "in process of formation" (Hopkins 1979:684).

The link between Mott's major role and his life purpose can be traced through the goals of the organizations he founded and to which he gave leadership, including the Young Men's Christian Association, Student Volunteer Movement for Foreign Missions, World Student Christian Federation, Foreign Missions Conference of North America, IMC, Interchurch World Movement, Institute of Social and Religious Research and the World Council of Churches.

**Mentoring Individual Leaders**

From the beginning of his ministry, Mott believed that new Christian leaders would experience an expanding scope of influence, just as he himself experienced throughout his life. At the age of twenty-seven, he wrote in one of his first pamphlets on the purpose of the SVM: "Not only does the Movement plan to enlist volunteers, but also to guard and develop them until they pass beyond its proper sphere of influence" (Mott 1892:92). Leadership development was an objective, not a mere byproduct of Mott's work with the many organizations and movements he founded or led.

In his lifetime, Mott was a mentor to many. He had a productive ministry in the lives of individuals, especially those associated with the boards and the organizations in

which he served as chairman or secretary. For those in succeeding generations Mott serves as an excellent historical mentor and as one who showed the true love of Christ.

**Bridge Building**

There are some people, including the Nobel Peace Prize Committee, who would argue that the single most important legacy of Mott was as a man of peace. Mott invested efforts on multiple occasions to bring together groups between which the friction was greatest. "…Britons and Boers: Americans and Spaniards: Chinese and Japanese: Japanese and Russians: English and Indians: American and Filipinos" (Rouse 1920:10). This ability to bring warring factions together related to the compelling nature of his own character. Mott's life ministry flowed out of this highly developed character. "The power in John R. Mott's personality was not simply the natural expression of a continuously flowing stream of personal energy, but was due to a . . . diligently developed technique for the unselfish service of the kingdom of God…(Matthews 1934:x).

**Writings**

Mott's writings influenced countless people of his generation. The most influential of his writings was *The Evangelization of the World in this Generation*; followed by the *Decisive Hour of Christian Missions*; and then *The Present Day Summons to the World Mission of Christianity*.

Samuel Zwemer, missionary to the Muslims wrote: "Dr. John R. Mott exerted his influence, first of all, on my life by his book *The Evangelization of the World in This Generation*… that book has, I think, widened the horizon for many of those who have gone to foreign fields… (Fisher 1952:99-100).

Kenneth Scott Latourette, historian, agreed: "It was your *Evangelization of the World in This Generation* which gave me one of my earliest and strongest impressions of the scope and purpose of the missionary enterprise" (Quoted in Fisher 1952:99-100).

### ***Summary***

Mott's contribution to the cause of world mission and world peace were recognized widely throughout his long life. By the time Mott was 32, he was called "Protestantism's leading statesman," at age 58, the "father of the young people of the world," and at age 81, in 1946, he was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize (Galli 2000).

All of the copious research and documentation available on Mott's life and ministry reveal a leader who changed the face of history of the church. The wave of missionaries he sent forth, the call he championed and the concepts of world evangelization he promoted, can never be called back. Leaders of any generation can still listen and learn from this dynamic leader. "Through faith, though he is dead, he still speaks" (Heb 11:4).

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